

Episode 102: Once Upon a Time... (62) – About Gyopi-chan and Cow-san in *Goldfish Warning!*

Recently, the book I ordered by Kamimura Sachiko-san, "Encyclopaedia of Animation Basics," arrived. I've been flipping through and reading (or rather, looking at) it during work breaks, and even familiar terms and various systems I use daily feel somehow fresh when compiled in a book like this. Moreover, facts like "huh? That's how it was? (sweat)" are revealed (laughs). Anyway, it's really well compiled and wonderful. Highly recommended.

Lately, except for magazines, I order almost all books through Amazon. I ordered this book on Amazon too and had it delivered to my home by courier. However, Amazon's courier packaging is mysterious. For example, this book is quite substantial so I wouldn't be surprised if it came in a "box," but they'll send even one DVD (not a DVD-BOX) in a "box," yet sometimes the same single DVD comes in simple cardboard envelope packaging delivered by mail service to the mailbox. What are the packaging & shipping criteria here? > Amazon

Personally, for single DVDs or books, I'm fine with simple packaging using mail service. Receiving courier deliveries is quite troublesome. You have to be home at the designated time. Previously when I was at Toei Animation, I had things sent to the studio, but now that's not possible...

Well, besides mail service handling, the accumulating "boxes" are quite stressful these days.

Now then.

Around 1992-93 when I was making *Coo: Far From Home*, I was approaching the milestone of turning 30. Looking at my work chronology, in 1992 while working on gradually starting COO, I was handling multiple parallel works including theatrical works for Toei Manga Festival (*Dragon Ball Z* etc.) and Toei Video OVAs (*Crying*

Freeman etc.). But in 1993 when COO production reached its climax, I seem to have focused on COO.

Previously, while holding theatrical and OVA works, I also maintained one TV series line, creating main character colours and colour direction sheets, deciding finishing conventions throughout the work, plus opening and ending colour direction, episode 1 colour direction.

But this became increasingly difficult due to theatrical work scheduling, and my involvement with TV series from *Saint Seiya*, *Akuma-kun*, *Moretsu Ataro* ended with *Goldfish Warning!* (きんぎょ注意報!) starting January 1991.

Huh? I haven't written about *Goldfish Warning!* have I? (sweat) Well, briefly...

Goldfish Warning! was an anime adaptation of Nekobe Neko's manga of the same name, broadcast on ANB network from January 1991. In Kanto it aired Saturday nights at 7 PM. Main staff included character designer Iriyoshi Satoru, art designer Mukuo Takashi, and series director Sato Jun'ichi.

Incidentally, this staff room included Ikuhara Kunihiro who made his directorial debut on the previous work *Moretsu Ataro*, plus assistant directors Igarashi Takuya and Uda Konosuke. Looking back, it was an incredibly luxurious lineup (laughs).

I probably wrote this before, but even when assigned TV series then, I was only allowed "startup" participation. So I handled main character colour design, several screen processing and screen effects foundations, opening and ending, plus episode 1 main story colour direction.

This system was honestly quite stressful from around then. I wanted to be involved in main story work. While creating solid foundations through "startup" was important and I felt entrusted with that, TV series develop and grow interesting through accumulated

episodes. So I couldn't participate at all once it became truly interesting. That was definitely stressful (grumble... well, similar treatment participation continues recently, causing super stress... grumble).

Goldfish Warning! was particularly stressful because it was interesting from the very beginning!

But my feelings didn't reach anyone, and as usual it was only "startup" participation.

For *Goldfish Warning!*, I created character colours referencing the original work's covers and colour pages, making everything generally light and bright. Above all, *Goldfish Warning!* was about the flying mysterious goldfish "Gyopi-chan" and the overwhelmingly present "Cow-san" (laughs).

In busy screens with lots of characters gathered, I aimed for balance where Cow-san's black would stand out distinctly. So Wapiko's sailor uniform and Shuichi's school uniform were made pale blue-purple tones.

There was much trial and error with Gyopi-chan's body pink colour, finally using paint called PB-1a. But this paint was technically a special colour forbidden for TV. Even so, I really wanted this colour and pushed it through saying "he's the star after all!" (laughs).

This work did quite innovative things for gag expressions then. For example, the so-called "tornado run." When characters ran in gag mode, instead of properly drawing feet, we made spiral-shaped abbreviated animation. Hence "tornado." Though we didn't call it that on set - we called it "spinning run" or something like that.

Also, something we definitely did in the previous work *Moretsu Ataro* too - drawing main lines extremely thick as if boldly drawn with magic markers for "wave splash!" expressions.

Initially we created thick lines by drawing outlines from thick lines drawn during key animation, making animation during in-betweens so the inside could be painted, then painting the inside black during finishing. But I think it was Sato-san who brought the thick pen from Print Gocco (popular then for drawing New Year's cards) saying "couldn't this be used with finishing trace machines?" Since the principle is the same - transferring animation to cels via trace machines and creating Print Gocco design masters - we tried it and it worked perfectly (laughs). So afterward this animation processing became drawing with Print Gocco thick pens during in-betweens (laughs).

Furthermore, we prepared dot pattern (polka dot) book materials for backgrounds, placing them over characters for so-called "sweat drip" expression cuts. Come to think of it, drawing big "sweat" behind characters' heads and sliding it might have started with *Goldfish Warning!*...

Anyway, *Goldfish Warning!* was made while trying various things. That *Goldfish Warning!* also ended after one year. The programmes afterward was *Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon*.

As written earlier, I didn't participate in *Sailor Moon*'s "startup" either. Incidentally, *Sailor Moon*'s startup was handled by Itasaka-san, then still at outsourced finishing production VAP. I felt somewhat frustrated (laughs), but was still curious so I went to peek at episode 1's staff preview. Got quite shocked (laughs).

A year and a half later, such *Sailor Moon* awaited me after COO ended. Ikuhara Kunihiko's directorial work *Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon R The Movie*.

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